1_DataColl2026SysConDRI_AlgTr.pdf

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Submission date: 21-Dec-2025 05:49PM (UTC-0800)
Submission ID: 2850404463
File name: 1_DataColl2026SysConDRI_AlgTr.pdf (270.44K)
Word count: 5638
Character count: 30777

Algorithmic Trading Subsystems Data Collection and Transformation Process Automation Using DRI for Machine Learning Modelling and Forecasting

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***Abstract*—This research paper focuses on developing an automated data collection and transformation framework for Algorithmic Trading (AT) forecasting using machine learning (ML). The implementation of the computational resources is supported by a grant from the Digital Research Alliance of Canada (DRAC), Alliance Cloud Connect Pilot cite DRI. This enables large-scale data processing, storage, and model training. Historical market data and real-time data streams are collected at 5-minute intervals, stored in staging tables of a PostgreSQL DBMS, and aggregated into 15-minute intervals in a custom-built Data Warehouse. It is essential to ensure that data from multiple sources remains consistent, accurate, and reliably reproducible throughout the data pipeline.**

***Index Terms*—Algorithmic Trading, Machine Learning Modelling, System Integration, Performance Optimization**

I. Introduction

The applied research paper discusses solutions for automatically acquiring complete historical and real-time datasets, as well as the significant storage and computational resources required to train a machine learning model for short-term Algorithmic Trading predictions. The focus during this phase of the project is on automating data collection and transformation.

The Alliance Cloud Connect Pilot allocated 200 core-years on the NIBI-compute system, 20.0 RGU-years on the nibi-gpu system, and 59 TB of project storage on the NIBI storage system for High Performance Computing (HPC). It also allocates 16 VCPU-years, 4 cloud instances, 32 GB of RAM, 7 volumes, 7 snapshots, 2 Floating IP addresses, and 60,000 GB of cloud volume and snapshot storage for the cloud allocations on the Arbutus-persistent-cloud system.

After a project is approved and resources are allocated, a few more steps are required to access them. One of the first steps is to set up Secure Shell (SSH) keys to access the resources. Another critical step was to set up Multi-factor Authentication (MFA), which is used when signing in to DRAC and when using the SSH tunnel to access the server. Furthermore, users must email DRAC to request access to specific resources, specify the required quantity, and wait for a reply before connecting to the dedicated PostgreSQL database.

With the provided resources, the data could be collected for the past thirty years. The previous work only included the three previous years. The new dataset is ten times larger than the previous datasets described in [1]–[7].

One of our biggest challenges is that many previous datasets are incomplete, leading to unexpected results with machine learning models. The current work focuses on updating missing values and expanding the dataset obtained from the data sources automatically.

The main contributions of this paper are (1) a new approach to data collection from external data sources for XGBoost training, testing, and stock forecasting; (2) the new and historical datasets uploaded to a PostgreSQL general purpose DBMS within DRI research project; and (3) the design and testing of a new API for direct access to the DBMS from the core subsystem as part of machine learning (ML) training, testing, and forecasting on the vast datasets collected, transformed, and stored in the DBMS.

This work is a continuation of the previous research projects described in [8]–[23].

II. Existing Works

In our previous papers, we analyzed existing work on algorithmic trading systems and ML algorithms for predicting stock prices, such as Al-Akashi and Hassan [24], Kolte et al. [25], and Li [26], and related statistical methods for prediction accuracy. R. K. Dubey in "Algorithmic Trading: The Intelligent Trading Systems and Its Impact on Trade Size" [27] reported about "lack of progress in developing an algorithmic trading system that is operationally efficient." "The main issues remain in acquiring, transforming, and storing the large datasets required for such a system" [28]. Many algorithmic trading and ML forecasting projects were limited by the size of the data set during model development and by the lack of system support for implementing the developed models [29].

Yulianto in [30] stressed that the "heterogeneity of data from various sources can be dealt with by designing an Extract, Clean, Conform, and Delivery/Load" process. Azeroual et al. [31] stated that implementing the ETL process could overcome many current challenges in data analysis. Oyewale et al. [32] informed that "market complexity and volatility, along with the volume and speed at which financial data is generated, shape the challenges surrounding stock market analysis." On the other hand, Haryono et al. [33] stressed that "ETL (Extract/Transform/Load) and ELT (Extract/Load/Transform) are the primary data processing methods for implementing a DW." Katari and Rodwal [34] identified issues in traditional ETL processes in financial markets. Our research over the last few years has confirmed that the ELT process is preferable to ETL.

Patel et al. in [35] outlined ETL tools, some of which are "code-based, GUI-based, cloud-based, Metadata support, Real-time support, and batch processing. Michael et al. discuss ETL systems for building a DW in their research. Biswas et al. in [36] described commercially available GUI-based products as ETL solutions. Ali [37] created an ETL framework for Big Data. On the other hand, relatively few papers investigate the complete data life cycle [38]. Wu et al. [39] proposed using Apache Airflow with Python scripts to automate ETL tasks. The previous analyses on several implementation techniques were documented in [7].

Based on the described works above and our research team's testing and observations, we use a well-established, proven object-oriented approach to design an efficient ELT process for this research project. The Python scripts, PostgreSQL DW, and a user interface (UI) are used to improve the performance of the ELT process.

III. A New Approach for Data Collection Automation using DRI

A. Overview of the Auto Data Collector System

In order to have accurate short-term forecasting, the model needs to always know recent market activity. The automated data collection system is designed to provide this by continuously updating the model dataset with current market information.

B. Cloud Deployment and Scheduling

The automated collector lives on a virtual machine instance within the Arbutus Cloud, part of Canada's Digital Research Infrastructure (DRI). The system runs on a p4-6gb instance, which provides 4 virtual CPUs, 6 GB of RAM, and a 20 GB persistent disk. Hosting the process in the cloud allows for consistent uptime, simple remote access, and protection against local hardware or power failures. Arbutus Cloud instances offer persistent storage, allowing the collector to run continuously without manual intervention needed. After about fifteen days of collection for 500 tickers, the PostgreSQL database uses roughly 100 MB of space, most of which is initial PostgreSQL table and index metadata rather than data records. This shows that the available storage is more than enough to support years of collected market data.

Job scheduling is managed using systemd timers, which run data collection at fixed intervals during standard market hours. This scheduling method ensures no data is missed, and reliable execution in the event of a network or system interruption. Each run creates a status log, forming a history of performance for easy review and debugging. This combination of stable cloud infrastructure with automated scheduling, supports a reliable data pipeline that stays synchronized with current market data and requires minimal operator oversight.

As shown in Listing 1, a systemd timer deployed on the VM triggers the collector throughout standard stock market hours.

Listing 1. Systemd timer for the Auto Data Collector

```
[Unit]
Description=Auto Data Collector Timer

# Run data collector twice per market hour
# Time in UTC on the VM
[Timer]
OnCalendar=Mon..Fri *-*-* 13:58
# Market open 09:30 EST
OnCalendar=Mon..Fri *-*-* 14:30
OnCalendar=Mon..Fri *-*-* 14:58
...
OnCalendar=Mon..Fri *-*-* 20:58
# Market closed 16:00 EST
OnCalendar=Mon..Fri *-*-* 21:30

Persistent=true
AccuracySec=1s

[Install]
WantedBy=timers.target
```

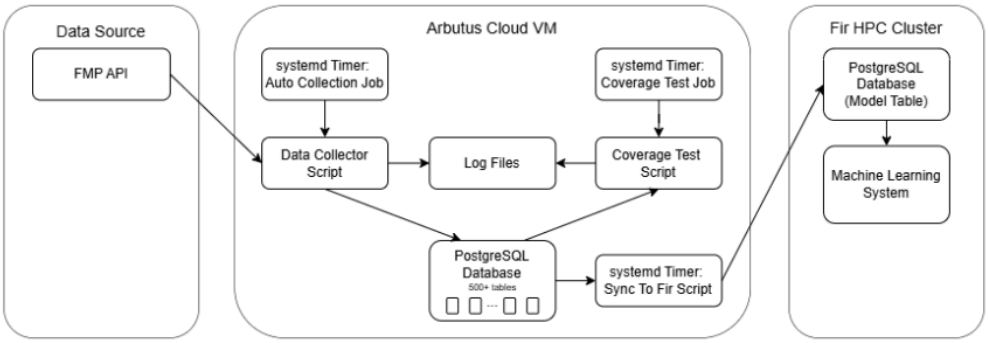

Fig. 1. Automated Data Collector Architecture and Workflow Design

The timer triggers the service shown in Listing 2, which executes the collector script.

Listing 2. Systemd service that runs the Auto Data Collector

```
[Unit]
Description=AutoDataCollector Service
# Ensure network is ready before running
After=network.target

[Service]
# Run the script once per timer trigger
Type=oneshot
User=almalinux
WorkingDirectory=.../AutoDataCollector/
# Entry script executed by the service
ExecStart=.../bin/run_collector.sh
# Retry if the script exits with an error
Restart=on-failure

[Install]
WantedBy=multi-user.target
```

C. Data Collection Process

The automated data collection process is handled by a Python script that runs on the virtual machine described in Section B. The collection script is designed to be run continuously throughout standard trading hours. During each execution, a time window is created which covers the most recent trading period, with a small overlap from the previous run to ensure no data are missed. As shown in Listing 3, the script computes a rolling one-hour EST window that ends twenty minutes before the current time, creating deliberate overlap between runs to ensure that no time interval is ever missed

Listing 3. Time window calculation used by the Auto Data Collector

```
# Determine rolling 1 hour time window
def get_current_time_window():
    now_ny =
        datetime.now(ZoneInfo("America/New_York"))

    # End window 20 minutes before now to
        ensure no missed rows from API
    end_time = now_ny.replace(second=0,
        microsecond=0) -
        timedelta(minutes=20)
    start_time = end_time -
        timedelta(hours=1)

    # Store timestamps in EST
    return start_time.replace(tzinfo=None),
        end_time.replace(tzinfo=None)
```

Data is extracted from the FMP API using this time window and the schedule is timed so that each collection happens shortly after new data is available. This keeps the database aligned with recent market activity with a slight lag.

The script uses lists of tickers so that symbols we want to track could be added or removed at any time and the collector would adjust. This makes the system flexible and easier to maintain as data requirements evolve. Because FMP provides timestamps in EST, the script preserves this format when inserting records into the PostgreSQL database. After retrieving recent data from FMP, the results are written to the database with an "upsert" operation, where entries are updated when already present, and inserted when not present yet. Listing 4 shows the portion of the collector that filters each record into the active time window and writes it to the corresponding ticker table using an UPSERT operation.

Listing 4. Filtering and UPSERT insertion of 5-minute records

```
# Fetch, filter, and upsert 5 minute
    market data into the staging table
rows = []
for record in data:
```

```
    ts = parse_fmp_timestamp(record["date"])
    if window_start <= ts < window_end and
        record.get("close") is not None:
        rows.append((
            record["open"],
            record["high"],
            record["low"],
            record["close"],
            record["volume"]
        ))

sql = f"""
    INSERT INTO {table} (ts, open, high,
        low, close, volume)
    VALUES %s
    ON CONFLICT (ts) DO UPDATE SET
        open=EXCLUDED.open,
            high=EXCLUDED.high,
        low=EXCLUDED.low,
            close=EXCLUDED.close,
        volume=EXCLUDED.volume;
"""
# Bulk insert all row tuples into DB
execute_values(cursor, sql, rows)
```

Running this process with systemd timers on the cloud based VM ensures a stable environment for collection, allowing the historical dataset to always be up to date, accurate, and ready for training the forecasting model.

D. Database Storage Architecture

The auto collector stores new market data in a set of staging tables in the database, with each ticker getting its own table. Each table uses OHLCV format (open, high, low, close, and volume), matching the structure provided by our data source (FMP API). These values describe how the market price moved during each time interval, and using the same format as the historical dataset keeps both sources consistent.

Every entry in the staging tables represents one 5 minute interval and is identified by its timestamp. Listing 5 shows the structure of a typical staging table, where the timestamp acts as the primary key and ensures that overlapping collection windows do not introduce duplicates.

Listing 5. Example staging table used for a single ticker

```
-- Staging table for a single ticker (AAPL)
CREATE TABLE IF NOT EXISTS market.aapl (
    ts    TIMESTAMP PRIMARY KEY,
    open  DOUBLE PRECISION,
    high  DOUBLE PRECISION,
    low   DOUBLE PRECISION,
    close DOUBLE PRECISION,
    volume BIGINT
);
```

Choosing the timestamp as the primary key allows the collector to easily update rows when collection windows overlap, and separating each ticker into its own table avoids write conflicts if many symbols were to be updated at the same time. This simple layout makes the storage layer easy to maintain and reliable for continuous data collection.

The staging tables serve as the first stop for new data. Their role is to hold recent market information in the same structure as the historical dataset. In a later step of the pipeline, both the historical data and the auto collected staging data are combined into a single model table used for training the forecasting model. That merging process is described in section: todo: add correct section here

E. Testing and Logging

Testing and logging are important parts of making sure the auto collector captures 100% of the expected market data for each market day. The system includes a daily coverage test that runs automatically about one hour after the market closes. Its job is to check that every 5 minute interval during standard trading hours was collected for every ticker. Listing 6 shows the core logic of the daily coverage test, which verifies that the expected number of five minute intervals was collected for each ticker.

Listing 6. Core logic of the daily coverage test

```
# Single ticker coverage between two dates
def coverage_for_symbol(conn, symbol,
    start_date, end_date):
    expected_per_day =
        expected_intervals_per_day()
    total_expected = 0
    total_actual = 0

    table = format_table_name(symbol)
    current = start_date

    with conn.cursor() as cur:
        while current <= end_date:
            # Skip weekends
            if current.weekday() >= 5:
                current += timedelta(days=1)
                continue

            # Intervals for one trading day
            total_expected += expected_per_day

            # Count found rows for that day
            open_dt =
                datetime.combine(current,
                time(9,30)).replace(tzinfo=None)
            close_dt =
                datetime.combine(current,
                time(16,0)).replace(tzinfo=None)

            cur.execute(
                f"SELECT COUNT(*) FROM {table}
                    WHERE ts >= %s AND ts < %s",
                (open_dt, close_dt),
            )
            total_actual += cur.fetchone()[0]

            current += timedelta(days=1)
```

```
# Return coverage percentage
return (total_actual / total_expected)
    * 100 if total_expected else 0
```

The test knows the start date of collection and adjusts its expectations as the days go on, so it continuously logs a coverage percentage for each ticker. This helped us catch several issues early, such as missing intervals, FMP API changes, and unexpected execution times. Finding these problems quickly made it much easier for us to ensure the dataset is complete and clean.

In addition to the coverage test, the collector writes a status log for every scheduled run, noting when the job started, when it finished, how long it took and whether any errors occurred. The coverage test also records its results in the logs. Together, these tests and logs provide essential visibility into the system's performance and ensure its data remains accurate over time.

IV. API Architecture, Design and Testing to DRI DBMS

– Helana: new API to the DBMS testing how to train and test data and explain in section IV

Follow ELT Process, instead of ETL.

From Financial Model Prep to Staging Tables: Extract raw stock, index, bond, and commodity data from Financial Model Prep API. Load raw data to individual staging tables. Used automatic collector described in Section III.

From Staging Tables to Model Table: Extract, transform, and merge data and store in the model table. Used a Jupyter Notebook.

From Model Table to Model / User Interface: Connect Model to Table; the Model will query Table to fetch training data. User Interface will be built in the future.

From From Staging Tables to Model Table in Detail: A Jupyter Notebook will extract the raw data from the staging tables, merge and transform the data and load them into a single table for model training.

Data Cleaning: FMP's raw data contains missing entries and duplicates. The Jupyter Notebook script creates a dataframe for each dataset, removes duplicates, and uses an *** appropriate imputation method (needs further research) to fill in the missing time entries.

Data Transformation: During this process, only categorical values are transformed. Numerical values are normalized during model training.

The data collection subsystem allows downloading historical data from CSV files and directly from the FMP API, and uploading to the staging database in PostgreSQL, thereby directly skipping the CSV file (Fig. 2).

V. The Automation Process Implementation

– James
– Youry, please review 2025-11-27

Due to limitations of Fir, the virtual machine on Arbutus Cloud is required to execute several of our scripts. Fir's crontab tool has been disabled and Fir has minimum requirements on job length; Arbutus Cloud provides access to scheduled tasks and has no limitations on job length. The regularity and short runtime of many scripts require large pieces of work to done outside the Fir database, split between Arbutus Cloud and local (personal) machines. Because of the disjoint databases on Fir and Arbutus Cloud, Fir's PostgreSQL database must be initialized with historical data, then updated with current stock information from the automatic data collector running on Arbutus Cloud.

A. Historical Stock Data Collection

– James
– Youry, please review 2025-11-27

The FMP API, configured for 5 minute intraday intervals, will return a maximum of 10 days' data per stock symbol, per API call. Due to the large number of API calls required, a script is needed to automate data collection across the desired date range. A Python script, running on a local machine, automates this process. The script defines a start date, end date, and stock symbols. Then, for each stock symbol, an inner loop iterates through the target range calling the API with distinct 5-day windows. Each time the inner loop terminates, the individual stock's results are saved locally into a CSV file named with the corresponding stock symbol. The outer loop terminates when all stock symbols have been processed. The resulting CSV files become input for a script which checks for missing entries. This Python date validation script loads each file based on the stock symbols defined in the data collector. Exclusion dates are inserted into a list (holidays, etc.) to avoid false alerts. The start date, end date, opening time, and closing time are also defined, matching the definitions in the historical data collection script. Expected 5-minute intervals are calculated, then actual results are then compared against the generated list. Any missing values are logged to the console for the operator to investigate. To confirm the API results were correct, missing entries are double-checked with a manual API call in a web browser. Occasionally FMP is missing data for an interval, but it is critical to validate the missing entry is a fault in FMP's data collection process and is unrelated to script execution. The raw data CSV's are ready to be patched (missing entries filled with previous entry's information, interpolated, etc.) and uploaded to the database.

B. CSV File to Database Upload Automation

– Brandon
– Youry, please review 2025-11-25

The CSV stock data is inserted into the Fir-hosted database using automated Python scripts, which are published on GitHub [40]. An SSH Tunnel to Fir and multi-

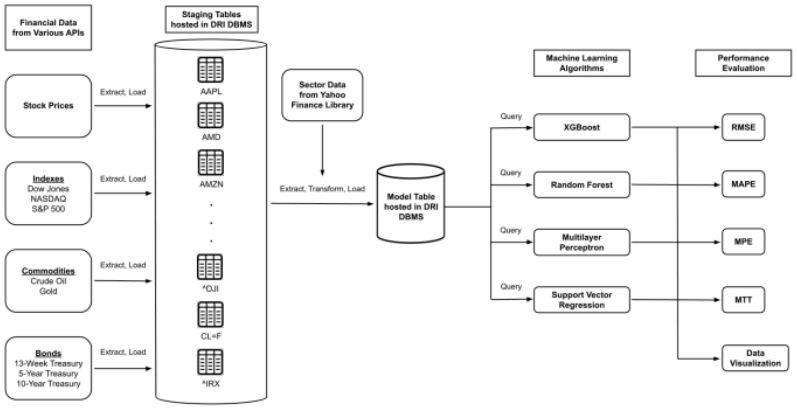

Fig. 2. Automated ELT Architecture of the Algorithmic Trading System

factor authentication had to be used to get access to the Fir PostgreSQL RDBMS [41], so the database is accessible. A stock CSV file is read into memory and is cast into the appropriate variable format for the database. As using multiple INSERT commands can take over 10 minutes per stock due to overhead, the script takes advantage of PostgreSQL's COPY command which acts as a bulk insert and takes approximately 5 seconds per stock. The script then iterates through the rest of the stock files until all data has been copied into their respective tables.

C. Current Stock Data Collection

– James
– Youry, please review 2025-11-27

In order to update the database with the latest stock information, the FMP API must be called continually throughout the day. The virtual machine on Arbutus Cloud, running a Bash shell on AlmaLinux, provides the mechanism through which the current data collection script is automated. A system timer is configured to run every 30 minutes, covering 4:00 am to 8:00 pm Eastern Standard Time, Monday through Friday. The timer's service executes a Bash script, which performs the following activities in this order: activate the Python virtual environment, initialize environment variables (API key and database connection), run the Python data collection script described in Section III.

D. Data Transformation for DW

– Brandon
– Youry, please review 2025-11-25

The raw data in the staging area is transformed into a single table, appropriate for the ML model. This table only consists of numerical data as ML models are highly mathematical in nature. The number of stocks in the staging area requires a repeatable transformation process.

The raw data is queried from the database and sent to Arbutus Cloud for Processing with a Python script. processing is done through python due to the extensive libraries that make data transformation easy. These libraries include pandas, holidays, and yfinance. Sector data is queried from yfinance for each stock and stored in a table. Each stocks data is read in from the table and is joined to the sector data using pandas. Commodity, bond, and index data is read in and joined to each individual stock on the date column. The holidays library retrieves a list of holiday dates that are used to see how pre holiday and post holidays affect the market. The date column is split into month, week, day, hour, and minute columns. To prevent ML models from trying to derive a relationship between different integer values in a single column the script takes advantage of one-hot encoding. This technique allows the script to split the original column into a set of boolean columns for each value present in the data.

Listing 7. One-hot Encoding

```
def one_hot(og_df, feature_to_encode):
    "Function that takes a dataframe, and a
        feature to one-hot encode and
        returns the dataframe with that
        feature encoded"
    dummies =
        pd.get_dummies(og_df[feature_to_encode],
        prefix = feature_to_encode,
        prefix_sep = "_")
    df = pd.concat([og_df, dummies], axis=1)
    df = df.drop([feature_to_encode],
        axis=1)
    return df
```

The transformed data gets inserted back into the

database.

E. DW and Staging Database Synchronization

– James
– Youry, please review 2025-11-27

AlmaLinux provides the firewalld service to manage port access. After opening the default PostgreSQL port, a public and private SSH key pair was generated and saved locally on the Arbutus VM. The ssh-copy-id command copies the public SSH key to Fir. A secure SSH tunnel to the Fir database is opened, using a non-dedicated port on the Arbutus VM as a local port. Finally, once the port-forwarding is setup is complete, the Arbutus terminal runs psql using the now open ssh tunnel. This completes the connection and the VM has command line access to the PostgreSQL database on Fir. A limiting factor of this method is the two-factor-authentication required for every Fir database connection. Future work for this section include discussions with the Digital Research Alliance of Canada to resolve the two-factor-authentication issue. Preferably, a connection will be established from Arbutus to Fir exclusively through internal DRAC tools or networks, as opposed to SSH which always requires Duo authentication. Another possibility is a persistent SSH tunnel, although a connection time out forcing re-authentication is a possible. The script to automatically insert rows has not yet been completed, but database access has been established, opening the possibility of fully automated database synchronization.

F. Testing Data Analysis Using new API from DW to Jupyter Notebook

The Fir cluster, which offers high-performance computing using GPUs, provides access to JupyterHub and JupyterLab for short tasks such as model training and testing. To access JupyterHub through the Fir server and use its GPUs, login through this link: https://jupyterhub.fir.alliancecan.ca/.

The model Notebook is uploaded to JupyterHub through the Fir Server. The model table is located in the Fir cluster so that the model can easily access the table. The model uses the psycopg2 and sqlalchemy packages to connect to the database and query the model table.

Listing 8. Database to Notebook Connection

```
engine =
    create_engine(f'postgresql://{username}:
   {password}@{host}:{port}/{database_name}')

query = "SELECT * FROM
    market.modelfeatures WHERE symbol IN
    ('AAPL', 'TSLA', 'MSFT')"

df = pd.read_sql(query, engine)
```

The model uses the pandas library to store the query data into a dataframe and uses the dataframe to train and predict the stock prices. The prediction results are stored and displayed on graphs.

VI. Future Works

In future research,

VII. Conclusion

Moreover, our research has emphasized that the architecture and design of an ETL system are pivotal in data warehousing.

Acknowledgements

We thank Okanagan College and the OC's GIA Committee for funding and financial support of the applied student research projects. Additionally, we would like to thank the DRA of Canada for the DRI Champions Award.

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